

HOW COMMUNITIES CAN STOP DESTRUCTIVE DEVELOPMENT PROJECTS IN THE REPUBLIC OF CONGO

INTRODUCTION & FRAMEWORK

Beneath the vast swamp forests of the northern Republic of Congo lies the **Cuvette Centrale**, the single largest tropical peatland found anywhere on earth — and what happens to it matters not only to the Congolese who live there but to the stability of the whole planet's climate. Shared with the neighbouring Democratic Republic of Congo, it holds on the order of **thirty billion tonnes of carbon** — as much as the entire world emits from fossil fuels in roughly three years — locked safely away in waterlogged peat beneath one of the great tropical rainforests, sheltering lowland gorillas, forest elephants, and rare life, and sustaining the fishing and forest communities who have always lived along its rivers. And it is threatened: the government has held and awarded oil exploration blocks that overlap the peatlands, on the basis of an environmental assessment so old that it predated the peatlands' own scientific discovery, while industrial logging presses at the forest's edge. There is no landmark community victory to point to, and no threat here has been finally beaten. But the peatlands' global value, and the bargain that could keep their carbon in the ground, give real ground.

Those who would protect the Cuvette Centrale work with real, if constrained, tools — worked carefully and largely through the international and the within-system. The peatlands' **global climate value** — thirty billion tonnes of carbon — is the foundational, evidence-based argument, bringing the world's climate movement, finance, and diplomacy to bear. The **state's own commitments to protect the peatlands** — the pledges it has signed, and its wish to be seen as a steward of the Congo Basin — can be held to, on its own terms. The **climate-finance bargain** — the world paying to keep the carbon in the ground rather than have it drilled — is a genuine lever that meets the nation's fair development need without the oil. The **weak economics and the flawed assessment** make peatland oil a bad and legally weak bet: the reserves are doubtful, and the environmental assessment underpinning the blocks predates the peatlands' own scientific discovery, so it can be challenged. And **pressure on the oil companies and their financiers**, through their climate and environmental standards, reaches the drilling from outside. But these tools have grave limits, and this guide states them plainly. The Republic of Congo is a genuinely poor, oil-dependent nation that badly needs revenue, and its government makes a fair argument that it has the same right to develop its resources that industrialised nations used. The political space to oppose is constrained, with real limits on dissent. And no threat here has been finally beaten. So the work must be careful, international-channelled, and framed around the global stakes, the state's own commitments, and the fair finance bargain — never around challenging authority — protecting the forest and Indigenous communities and any advocate whose position could be jeopardised. And the honest path is not to deny a poor nation its development, but to fund a better one — so aim for the drilling scrutinised and slowed, the state held to its pledges, and the finance bargain advanced that keeps the carbon in the ground, not an open defeat of a needed revenue source.

The Whole Strategy in One Idea

You cannot justly deny a poor nation its development, nor safely mount open confrontation in a constrained state. What you can do is make the global bargain: press the peatlands' climate value, hold the state to its own commitments, challenge the drilling's weak economics and its assessment that predated the peatlands' discovery, pressure the oil companies and financiers — and, above all, advance the climate finance that

pays the nation to keep the carbon in the ground rather than drill it. The honest path is to fund a better development, not to forbid development itself.

Be Honest About Which Fight You're In

The Republic of Congo is a poor, oil-dependent, constrained setting, and honesty about that is the first discipline — including the honesty that its government has a fair claim to develop, as industrialised nations did. This is not a fight you win by denial or confrontation. It is a careful, international-channelled effort whose realistic prize is the drilling scrutinised and slowed, the state held to its pledges, and the finance bargain advanced — not an open defeat of a needed revenue source. Frame everything around the global stakes and the fair bargain, and protect the communities and advocates whose position could be jeopardised.

HOW THE SYSTEM WORKS

Who Actually Decides

Power over the oil rests with a constrained state that badly needs the revenue. But the decisions a careful effort can reach run through the global and the within-system: the **international climate, forest, and transparency movements and diplomacy**, the **climate-finance channels** that could pay to keep the carbon in the ground, the **oil companies and their financiers** and the standards they answer to, and the **state's own commitments and stewardship ambitions**. Map who decides, and where it is safe to act, before spending a week on it.

How a Project Moves — and Where You Jump In

An oil block advances by government award and company exploration, resting on an environmental assessment that predates the peatlands' discovery. The point of entry is that flawed assessment and the weak economics: a documented case can challenge the outdated study, question the doubtful reserves, and press the global climate value. Alongside it, the entry point is the bargain — advancing the climate finance and the state's own commitments so the nation can choose the carbon over the drill. Enter always where it is safe, framed around the global stakes.

Follow the Money and the Permissions

Follow the carbon: how much the peatlands hold, and what the world would pay to keep it locked. Follow the oil: which companies and financiers hold the blocks, what the reserves are truly worth, and what climate and environmental standards they answer to. Follow the assessment: how old and flawed the study underpinning the blocks is. The leverage lies in the global climate value, the finance bargain, the weak economics, the flawed assessment, and the financiers' standards.

Who's Supposed to Be Watching

Domestic oversight is constrained, but the international climate and forest movements, the transparency and finance bodies, the oil companies' own financiers and standards, and the diplomacy of a state that wants Congo Basin stewardship are the channels a careful case engages — holding each to the global stakes, the state's commitments, and the standards.

QUICK REFERENCE: SUCCESS RATES

No Congolese effort easily halts a needed oil revenue source, and honesty requires saying so — the nation is poor and the space constrained. But the peatlands' global value, the state's commitments, the finance bargain, and the flawed assessment are real. The single most decisive move is **making the global bargain — the finance to keep the carbon in the ground** — because it answers the nation's fair development need without the drilling, and turns a confrontation into an offer the state can accept. The climate value is the foundation; the finance bargain the distinctive lever; the weak economics and flawed assessment the sharpest handles. The realistic prize is the drilling scrutinised and slowed, the state held to its pledges, and the finance advanced — pursued carefully and safely.

STEP 1: TARGET IDENTIFICATION

Ask five questions. **What is the harm?** — the oil blocks over the peatlands, the logging at the edge, the carbon at risk. **What is the global stake?** — the thirty billion tonnes of carbon and the world's climate interest. **What is the bargain?** — the climate finance that could pay to keep the carbon in the ground. **What is weak in the project?** — the doubtful reserves and the assessment that predated the peatlands' discovery. **How is everyone kept safe?** — the overriding question, answered by staying international-channelled and protecting the communities and advocates. Pick the harm where the global value and the finance bargain offer the clearest, safest handle.

STEP 2: DOCUMENTATION — HOW TO BUILD AN UNASSAILABLE CASE

Build the case in layers, framed around the global stakes. **Layer one: the value and the harm** — the peatlands' carbon and biodiversity, the oil blocks that overlap them, the logging pressure. **Layer two: the weakness and the commitment** — the doubtful oil economics, the assessment that predated the peatlands' discovery, and the state's own signed commitments to protect them. **Layer three: the bargain and the safety** — the climate finance that could keep the carbon in the ground, and the discipline of framing everything around the global stakes and the fair bargain, protecting the communities and advocates. A case built on the global carbon value, the flawed assessment, and the finance bargain is one the world's movements, the financiers, and even the state can engage.

WHAT TO GATHER, AND WHERE TO FIND IT

Gather the **value record**: the peatlands' carbon and biodiversity science, the global climate stake. Gather the **harm record**: the oil blocks overlapping the peatlands, the logging, the assessment underpinning them and its age. Gather the **weakness record**: the doubtful oil reserves and economics, the flaws in the assessment. Gather the **commitment-and-finance record**: the state's signed pledges, its stewardship ambitions, and the climate-finance channels that could pay to keep the carbon in the ground. Gather the **channel record**: the international climate and forest movements, the financiers, the transparency bodies. Gather the **safety discipline**: confirm the case stays international-channelled and protects the communities and advocates.

STEP 3: BUILDING THE INTERNATIONAL AND COMMUNITY COALITION

Build the coalition carefully: the **international climate, forest, and transparency movements**, who bring finance and diplomacy to bear; the **climate-finance bodies** that could fund the bargain; the **oil companies' financiers and standards watchdogs**, who can reach the drilling; and, carefully, the **forest and Indigenous communities** of the Cuvette Centrale, whose home and livelihood are at stake — protected always. Frame the effort around the global stakes, the state's commitments, and the fair finance bargain, never around challenging authority, and protect any advocate whose position could be jeopardised.

STEP 4: CLIMATE-VALUE, COMMITMENT & FINANCE LEVERS — CONTESTING THE HARM CAREFULLY

Set expectations honestly: the levers are real but constrained, the nation needs revenue, and the work must be careful and international-channelled.

The Global Climate Value and the State's Commitments

The peatlands' **global climate value** — thirty billion tonnes of carbon — is the foundational lever, bringing the world's movements, finance, and diplomacy to bear. And the **state's own signed commitments to protect the peatlands**, and its wish to be seen as a Congo Basin steward, can be held to on its own terms.

The Weak Economics and the Flawed Assessment

The **doubtful oil reserves and the outdated assessment** make peatland oil a bad and legally weak bet: the economics are poor, and the environmental assessment underpinning the blocks predates the peatlands' own scientific discovery, so it can be challenged as defective — a genuine legal handle.

The Finance Bargain and the Financier Pressure

The distinctive lever is the **climate-finance bargain** — the world paying to keep the carbon in the ground, meeting the nation's fair development need without the drilling — reinforced by **pressure on the oil companies and their financiers** through their climate and environmental standards. Pursued together — the climate value and commitments, the weak economics and flawed assessment, and the finance bargain — these levers contest the harm carefully and offer the state a better path, while protecting the communities and advocates.

TURNING YOUR EVIDENCE INTO ARGUMENTS

Tailor the case, always around the global stakes and the bargain. **For the climate movements and finance bodies**: here is the world's carbon at risk, and here is the finance that could keep it in the ground. **For the state**: here are your own commitments, your stewardship ambition, and a bargain that funds development without drilling the peat. **For the oil companies and financiers**: here is a weak, high-risk bet that fails the climate standards you answer to. **For the world**: here is a global treasure, and a fair path that neither denies a poor nation nor drills the carbon. **The golden rule**: frame everything around the global stakes, the state's commitments, and the fair finance bargain, never around challenging authority, and protect the communities and advocates.

STEP 5: MEDIA STRATEGY

Media must be handled with care in a constrained state. Frame the story around the **global peatland treasure and the fair bargain**: the world's largest tropical peatland, its thirty billion tonnes of carbon, and a

path that funds a poor nation's development without drilling the peat — never around challenging the government. Carry it through the international climate and forest outlets, the finance and transparency networks, and the diplomacy. A few cautions govern everything: keep it framed around the global stakes and the bargain; never frame it as a challenge to authority; protect the communities and advocates; and let the carbon value, the flawed assessment, and the finance bargain carry the weight.

EMAILS & LETTERS

Keep every message framed around the global stakes and the fair bargain, and protective of the communities and advocates.

8A — To an international climate or forest movement: set out the peatlands' carbon at risk and ask for engagement and finance.

8B — To a climate-finance body: present the bargain — finance to keep the carbon in the ground — and ask how it could be advanced.

8C — To the state (framed around its commitments): recall its signed pledges and stewardship ambition, and offer the finance bargain as the path.

8D — To an oil company: set out the weak economics and the flawed assessment, and ask how the project meets the climate standards it answers to.

8E — To a financier: present the high-risk, high-carbon bet and ask how the financing meets the institution's commitments.

8F — On the assessment: document that the study predates the peatlands' discovery and press for a proper, current assessment.

8G — To a transparency or diplomacy body: describe the global stakes and request engagement.

8H — To the international public: summarise the treasure, the threat, and the fair bargain, and ask for support — without exposing anyone.

IF YOU HAVE LITTLE TIME: THE RAPID-FIRE VERSION

The first 48 hours: assemble the peatlands' carbon value, the oil blocks overlapping them, and the age of the assessment; write the one-page global-stakes-and-bargain case; identify the safest channel — usually an international climate movement or a finance body. **The fastest-moving levers:** the global climate value, the finance bargain, and the flawed assessment. **Emergency coalition-building:** reach the international climate and forest movements and the finance bodies first — safely and framed around the stakes. Throughout, protect the communities and advocates.

WHEN THE SYSTEM IS TILTED

The field here is tilted by a poor, oil-dependent, constrained state with a fair claim to develop. Recognise it and adjust the aim — not denial, but the drilling scrutinised and slowed and a better development funded. Lean on the levers the tilt cannot easily reach: the global climate value, the finance bargain, the flawed assessment, the financiers' standards. And accept the honest limits — the nation needs revenue and no threat has been finally beaten — while still holding the state to its commitments and advancing the bargain that keeps the carbon in the ground, and protecting everyone.

WHEN IT'S ACTUAL CORRUPTION — AND WHO BENEFITS

Distinguish the ordinary tilt from capture — oil blocks steered to insiders, assessments waved through, revenue that vanishes. Where capture appears, respond only through the **international and finance channels**: the transparency bodies, the financiers' standards, the climate movements, the documented record. Never through open confrontation. **On safety and care**: this note matters throughout. The Republic of Congo is a constrained state with real limits on dissent. Favour the international climate, forest, and transparency movements, the finance channels, and careful documentation over open confrontation; protect individuals, especially the forest and Indigenous communities and any local advocates whose position could be jeopardised; frame the work around the global stakes, the state's commitments, and the fair finance bargain, never around challenging authority; and handle the government factually. Care is the first rule.

INTEGRATION & TIMELINE: RUNNING ALL FIVE STEPS TOGETHER

The steps run in parallel, framed around the global stakes and only where safe. The documented value and harm feed the climate-value argument, the assessment challenge, and the finance bargain at once; the international and community coalition organises carefully alongside; the media carries the treasure-and-bargain frame throughout. A rough timeline: **weeks one to four**, assemble the carbon value, the harm, and the flawed assessment; **months two to six**, press the climate movements, the finance bodies, the financiers, and the state's commitments, and advance the bargain; **beyond**, sustain the finance and the scrutiny toward keeping the carbon in the ground. The core discipline: global-stakes-framed, finance-bargain-driven, careful, and absolute in protecting the communities and advocates.

FINAL ASSESSMENT

The Republic of Congo is a poor, oil-dependent, constrained ground, and this guide does not pretend otherwise — including that its government has a fair claim to develop, as industrialised nations did. It does not claim a needed revenue source can simply be denied, or that the space is open, or that a threat has been finally beaten. What it claims is narrower and real: that the Cuvette Centrale is a global treasure holding thirty billion tonnes of carbon; that the state has signed commitments to protect it and wants Congo Basin stewardship; that the oil beneath is of doubtful worth and rests on an assessment that predated the peatlands' discovery; that the oil companies and financiers answer to climate standards; and that, above all, the world could pay to keep the carbon in the ground. The levers are constrained, the work careful and international-channelled, and the prize is the drilling scrutinised and slowed and a better development funded — not an open defeat of a poor nation's revenue. But for a globally vital peatland in a poor state, that careful, bargain-driven effort — funding a better development rather than denying development itself, and protecting the communities and advocates — is not a lesser ambition. It is the responsible and effective one.